Usability Test Report

TWC 444

Amee Minter

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User Experience

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Introduction

Solera is a gated retirement community in Chandler, Arizona. Solera has an HOA (homeowner association) which is managed by a local board and a professional management company. The management company provides Solera with its own community website.

A usability study was created and implemented to determine how easily users can access information and functionality on the community website. Participants were provided with a scenario and asked to complete tasks relating to HOA services. Tasks were designed to test whether participants were able to complete each task with ease or difficulty. At the conclusion of the usability test, the researcher determined that the following recommendations would give users a greater chance of successfully completing similar tasks in the future. The recommendations are to redo the login page, rename and reorganize navigation headings and subcategories, allow for online submission of forms, and to add a website accessibility widget to the site.

Website

The website used for this report is solerachandlerhoa.org (Figure 1). The Solera community is professionally managed by AAM, an HOA management company that provides each of its communities with their own website. The Solera website includes information about the community including events, contact information for neighbors, a newsletter, and videos of board meetings. Users can also access community governing documents, forms, and data.

As a user id and password are required to access the Solera website, participant Lynne shared this information with the researcher with the knowledge that her login credentials will be needed until this report has been thoroughly reviewed.

Figure 1: solerachandlerhoa.org login page.

Test Method

Pre-Test

Participants completed the study in person at the home of participant #3. Each participant was tested separately using the researcher's laptop (Dell Inspiron 16 Plus, running Windows 11 Home) and wireless mouse (Logitech M510). Waiting participants were completely isolated from the current participant and could not see or hear the ongoing test.

The researcher sat to the left of each participant with printouts of a Welcome Script (Appendix A), Background Scenario and Tasks (Appendix B), three blank copies of Problems and Thoughts (Appendix C), and three copies of the Post Test Survey (Appendix D). The researcher placed a mobile phone on the table to record audio of each participant. The researcher also had a pen and notebook. The notebook was used on the researcher's lap for stability during notetaking as

notetaking on the table would have allowed participants to view the notes and possibly become distracted.

At the start of each test the laptop displayed the login page for the Solera Chandler HOA website.

Test & Post-Test

Once the participant was seated before the laptop, the researcher completed the following steps:

1. Read welcome script to participant and answered any questions.
2. Began recording audio on mobile phone.
3. Read background scenario and first task to participant.
4. Allowed participant to work on the task until completion or researcher intervention.
5. Asked participant where they had problems and what they were thinking.
6. Made notes from step 5 on Problems and Thoughts sheet.
7. Logged onto the website.
8. Read 2nd task to participant and repeated steps 4-6.
9. Read 3rd task to participant and repeated steps 4-6.
10. Asked participant Post-Test survey questions and took notes.
11. Thanked participant and ended audio recording.
12. Labelled participant's Problem and Thoughts and Post-Test Survey sheets appropriately.
13. Logged off website.
14. Reset browser to login page.

Steps 1-14 were completed for the other two participants.

Once all testing was completed the researcher reviewed the audio recording to make note of each participant's time on task. This was also an opportunity for the researcher to review paths and any comments that were missed during notetaking.

Participants

This usability test was conducted using three participants who are all residents of Solera (Table 1). The only criteria for participants besides residency were that they have experience browsing the internet using a mouse. The participants consisted of an 83-year-old female, 83-year-old male, and 73-year-old female.

Table 1: Participant Demographics.

Participant	Age	Gender	Employment	Position Prior to Retirement
#1 Mary	83	Female	Retired	Dillard's buying office
#2 Jack	83	Male	Retired	Jewelry sales
#3 Lynne	73	Female	Retired	Medical transcriptionist

Findings

Observations, review of audio recordings, notes, and completed Post-Test Surveys lead the researcher to believe that completion of the tasks was somewhat difficult for all three participants as none managed to complete more than two tasks. Below is a table summarizing task results, followed by a more in depth break down:

Table 2: Participant Task Results.

	Participants		
Tasks	Mary	Jack	Lynne
#1 Log in	✓	✗	✓
Time on Task	2m 54s	2m 14s	2s
#2 E-form	✗	✗	✗
Time on Task	3m 21s	3m 16s	2m 03s
#3 Pay fee	✓	✓	✓
Time on Task	1m 49s	1m 44s	23s

Task #1-You would like to sign into the website. How would you do this?

Mary completed this task but did not realize it until the researcher let her know. She clicked on Welcome in the navigation bar three times and moved the mouse around the page and scrolled down to read all the content. She expressed that Welcome seemed to be the place to start as nothing else was clear. "Welcome means welcome in". She was just starting to get frustrated and randomly clicking when she accidentally hit the large image on the right-hand side of the page which opened the login screen (Figure 2).

Figure 2 Image expanded to show login

Jack was unable to complete this task. He also kept clicking on Welcome and scrolled up and down. He stated he has vision issues and the "print is too small". When shown where to log in he said the login didn't look like others he was used to and he expected it to be front and center on the page.

Lynne completed this task within seconds. She admitted that she is often on the site. She clicked on Resident sign-in in the upper right-hand corner. She never noticed the larger sign-in until it was shown to her. She stated, "I'd never think to look there".

Task #2-You are now logged onto the website. You want to add a fence in your backyard and need HOA approval. The HOA requires you submit a request form. How would you submit this form online?

Mary was unable to complete this task. She initially focused on the information in the box containing resident Susan Damasco's info. She clicked and scrolled within this grey box of content before clicking on Welcome>Community Information, then Welcome again, then HOA Services and finally Documents. Once in documents she looked at the expandable folders on the left of the page but changed her focus to the Need Help field and was too frustrated to continue. Mary thought links to forms would be in the middle of the page in the grey box (Figure 3) and wouldn't require so much digging.

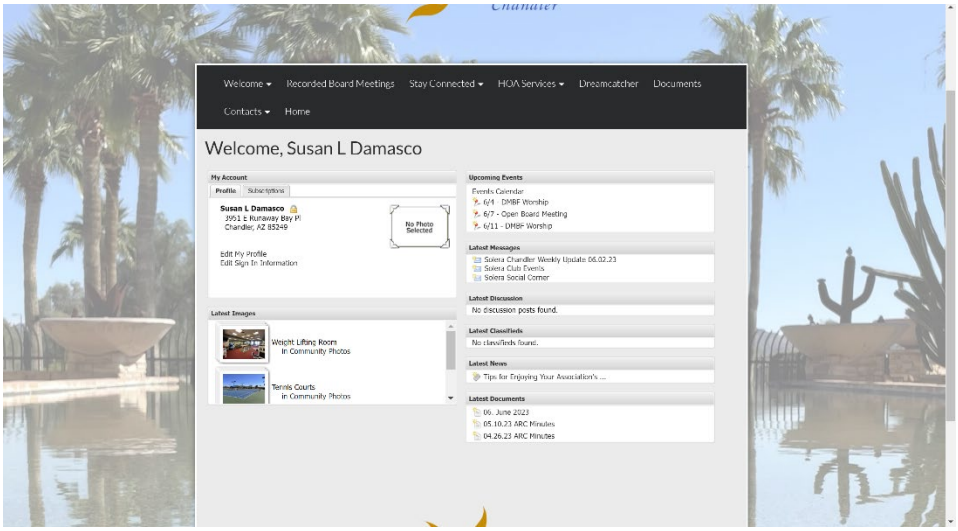

Figure 3 Page after login

Jack concluded that submitting an E-form didn't seem possible. He felt this was remiss as submitting forms for HOA approval is a common occurrence. His path was Documents>Printable Forms>ARC Request>View Online. This was the proper form but could not be completed online and submitted. It would have to be printed out and then scanned and emailed or walked over to the Solera clubhouse office. The researcher showed him that by clicking on Contacts>E-Forms the user would be brought to a page without any E-form links (Figure 4).

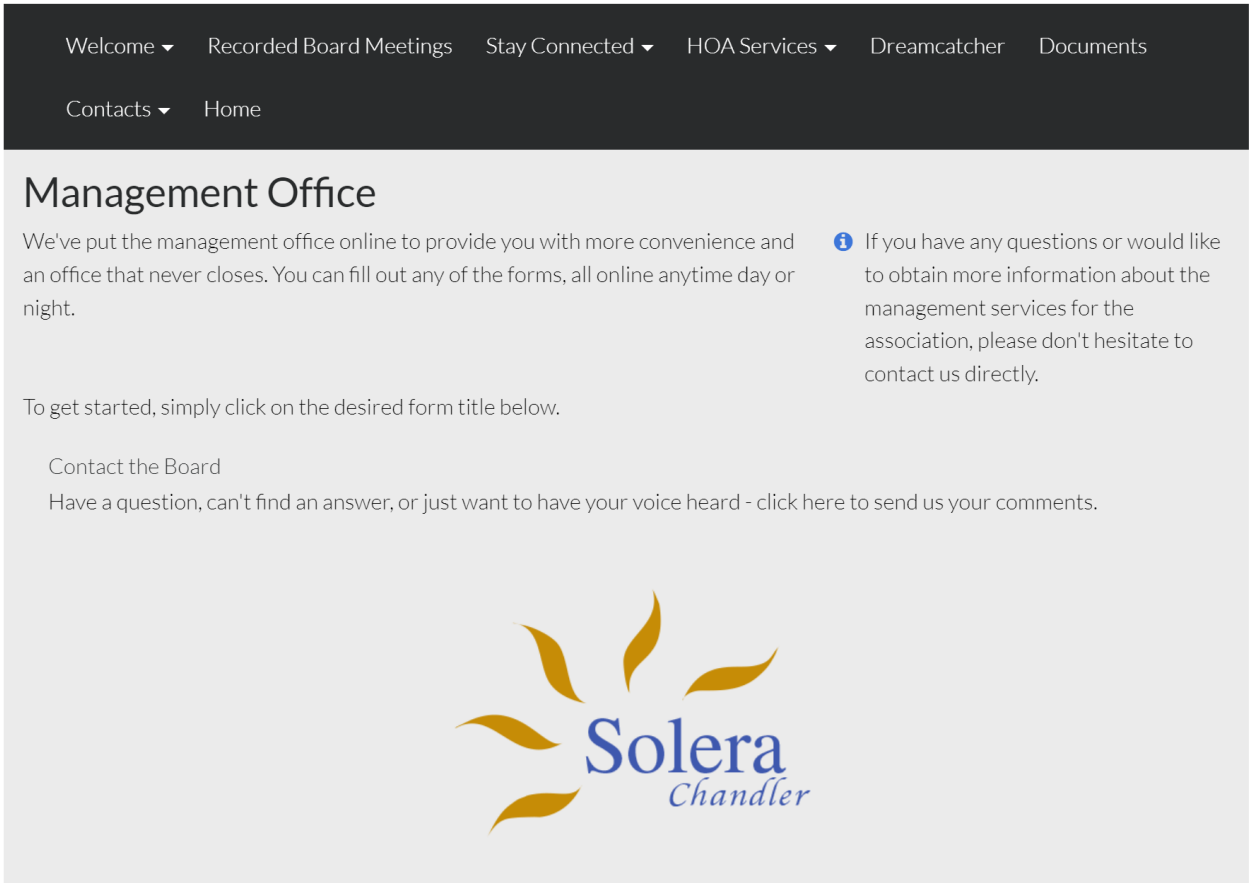

Figure 4 E-Form page

Lynne was able to find the correct form but concluded that she would not be able to submit it online either. When asked how she submits form she said that she either gets a blank form from the clubhouse office or prints it off online. She then fills it out and brings it back to the office at the clubhouse.

Task #3-It's Sunday morning and you realize you haven't paid your HOA fee yet and it's due by midnight. How would you make a payment online today?

Mary was able to complete this task by taking the path: HOA Services>Payment Options. At that point she became unsure because she didn't know where the two clickable buttons would take her and she at first didn't realize that the titles of the list of payment methods were link. She

eventually clicked on the first payment option, Pay Once. She tried to read the information about that method but said it was too difficult to read. When she ended up on the 3rd party payment site, she said she thought it looked "fishy". She currently has the HOA fee deducted automatically from her bank account but says she knows not everyone is financially able to do that.

Jack was able to complete this task as well using the same path as Mary. He too said he could not read the information about the payment method very well and also thought the 3rd party payment site looked "unofficial".

Lynne completed the task using the same path as Mary and Jack. She was able to read the payment information and noticed that it could take 72 hours for payment to post to the account. She wasn't sure if the payment would be late. She also noticed that the name given for the 3rd party payment site, PayLease, wasn't the name of the actual payment site, which was Zego.

Recommendations

The researcher has three recommendations to improve the usability of the Solerachandlerhoa.org website. The recommendations are based on the researcher's observations of participant verbal and non-verbal output during the test cycle. Some recommendations were also chosen for their simplicity. "What's the smallest, simplest change we can make that's likely to keep people from having the problem we observed?" (Krug, 2010, p. 167).

Redo the Login Page

Except for Lynne, who often uses the site, the other participants didn't know where to go to log in. This could be solved by having a simple login box in the center of the page with no other

content. The login would be completely above the fold even with a browser set at well over 100% zoom.

Rename and Reorganize Navigation Headings

Nonsensically, E-Forms is located under Contacts and HOA Services has a subheading of HOA Services. Heading and Categories should be card sorted into more logical groupings. A more drastic measure would be to divide the website into two major functions: community connections and HOA services. The site is used to network with neighbors but it's also where forms can be submitted and fees paid.

Make the E-Forms Functional

The E-Forms page is mislocated under Contacts and lacks functionality and content. Move E-Forms under Documents and allow users the choice to fill out and submit them online. This will be helpful for users that have mobility issues or lack scanners.

Add a Website Accessibility Widget

The users in the Solera community are 55 and older and with age come age related issues that can make accessibility challenging. All three participants complained of readability issues. The Solera HOA website should have an accessibility widget available on the login page. It should be highly visible, easy to use, and above all assist users to interact with the site effectively and as painlessly as possible.

Conclusion

The Solera HOA website is not user friendly from the get-go. It is as if the site was designed without regard to who the users are and what they would be trying to accomplish. Usability

testing was conducted with participants who were asked to complete common tasks on their retirement community's website. Some of the problems are:

- Difficulty logging in
- Accessibility Issues
- Lack of functionality
- Lack of organization

Based on the testing, recommendations were made to increase the usability of the site. These recommendations are:

- Redo the login page
- Rename and Reorganize Navigation Headings and Subcategories
- Make the E-Forms Functional
- Add a Website Accessibility Widget

The researcher is confident that implementation of the recommendations will increase use of the site. Tasks will require less effort and users will enjoy interacting with the site more. The HOA will also be a part of making its business more inclusive.

References

Solera Chandler - Solera Chandler homeowners association inc. Solera Chandler - Solera Chandler Homeowners Association Inc. (n.d.). https://www.solerachandlerhoa.org/

Krug, S. (2010). *Rocket Surgery Made Easy: The Do-it-yourself Guide to Finding and Fixing Usability Problems*. New Riders Pub.

Appendix A

Welcome Script (Krug, 2010)

Hi, I'm going to be walking you through this session today.

I'm asking people to try using a website that I'm working on so I can see whether it works as intended. I be asking you to engage in 3 tasks on the site.

The first thing I want to make clear is that I'm testing the *site*, not you. You can't do anything wrong here and there are no wrong answers.

As you use the site, I'm going to ask you to try to think out loud: to say what you're looking at, what you're trying to do, and what you're thinking.

Please don't worry that you're going to hurt my feelings. I'm doing this to improve the site, so I need to hear your honest reactions.

If you have any questions just ask them, but I may not be able to answer right away, since I'm interested in how people do when they don't have someone helping them. If you need to take a break at any point, just let me know.

With your permission, I'm going to record our conversation. The recording will only be used to help me figure out how to improve the site, and it won't be heard by anyone else.

Do you have any questions so far?

Appendix B

Background Scenario

You live in Solera, a 55+ retirement community in Chandler, AZ. Solera's HOA has a community website that includes a range of features and functionality. You will explore some of this functionality by engaging in the following tasks.

Instructions: Please complete the following tasks without using the search bar. Remember to take your time and to think out loud while you are completing them.

Task #1

You would like to sign into the website. How would you do this?

Task #2

You are now logged onto the website. You want to add a fence in your backyard and need HOA approval. The HOA requires you submit a request form. How would you submit this form online?

Task #3

It's Sunday morning and you realize you haven't paid your HOA fee yet and it's due by midnight. How would you make a payment online today?

Appendix C

Problems and Thoughts

Task #1-sign in

Where did you encounter problems?

What were your thoughts?/Why did you make that decision?

Path and time on task:

Task #2-forms

Where did you encounter problems?

What were your thoughts?/Why did you make that decision?

Path and time on task:

Task #3-pay fee

Where did you encounter problems?

What were your thoughts?/Why did you make that decision?

Path and time on task:

Appendix D

Post Test Questionnaire

1. What is your age?
2. How often do you browse the internet?
3. Which device/s do you primarily use?
4. Do you currently work?
5. What did you do before you retired?
6. Have you used this website before?
7. What did you like about this website?
8. What did you not like?
9. How hard or easy was it for you to complete the tasks?
10. What would you change?
11. How do you currently pay your HOA fee?
12. How do you currently submit forms?
13. Would you use the solerachandlerhoa.org site in the future? Why or why not?